

our only source of income. It is important to those of us who work in it and to those who don't. The children have grown up in and around the business. All have a keen attachment to it.

This was exactly the sort of “buy-in” for the family office that we were looking for. There are six children in the family. They have very different interests and professions—physical therapy, acting, medical school, geology, and music. We had been concerned that it would be difficult to get them all involved in our family office project. It turned out not to be difficult at all.

During the meeting, we also talked about the family properties, family budgets, our schedule for the year ahead, charities, cost control, and a number of other issues. At the end of the meeting, we went around the room and asked everyone for his “takeaway.” Everyone seemed to have learned something; the family office was on its way.

WHO SHOULD SIT ON THE FAMILY COUNCIL?

Filling your Family Council with capable family members will be a huge help in preserving your family's legacy. The selection process depends on your family culture. Typically, in the first and second generations, all family members are part of the Family Council. Everyone is expected to familiarize himself with the issues affecting the family and to participate in the decision-making process. Young family members can start participating in the Family Council in their early teens.

But when your Family Council reaches 15 to 20 people, it is best to switch to a representative system. Under this system, an elected senior family member will represent different family branches to avoid the Family Council becoming unwieldy.

Most American and European families include spouses in their meetings. Excluding people who play such an important role in the family can breed ill will toward the Family Council. Spouses are influential over the lives of current and future family members. It would be a mistake to alienate them.